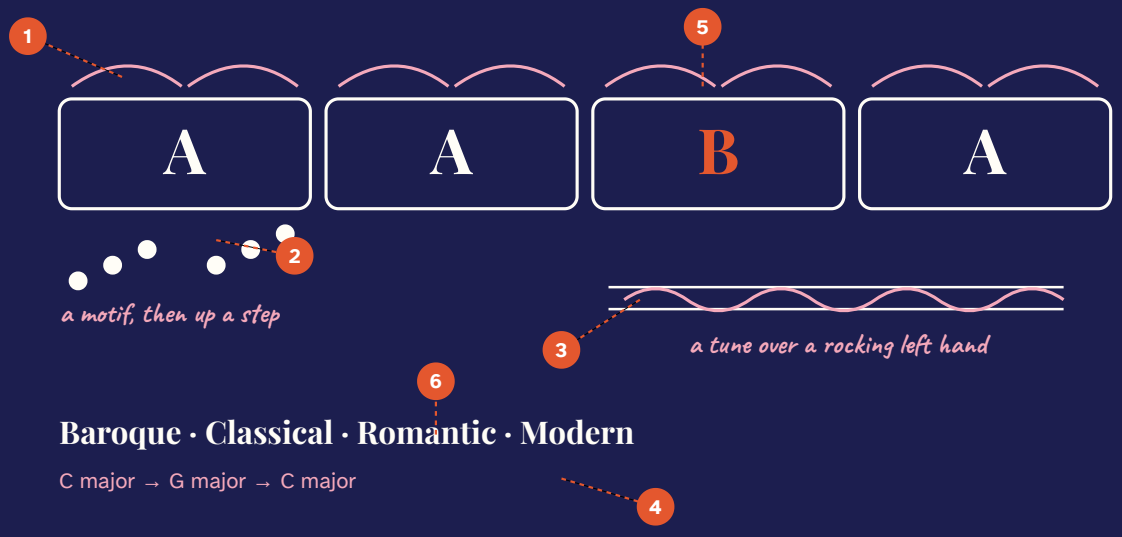
PART VII · HOW MUSIC IS BUILT

# Shape and style

Step back from the notes and see the building: small ideas, repeated and moved, in sections that come and go, in the style of their time. Everything in this part is on this map.





1 **Motifs and phrases** p. 148
small ideas build sentences: question and answer

2 **Repetition and sequence** p. 150
say it again, higher, in another voice, or something new

3 **Texture** p. 152
one line, a tune with chords, or tunes woven together

4 **Changing key** p. 154
a new sharp that keeps coming back: a new key

5 **Form** p. 156
the map of a piece: AB, ABA, ABACA, variations

6 **Styles through time** p. 159
Baroque, Classical, Romantic and Modern

★ **Tips: when a piece goes nowhere** p. 161

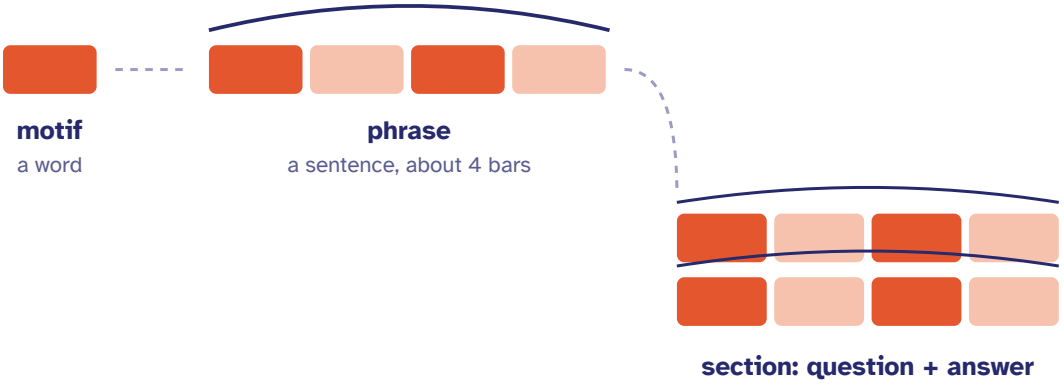
PART VII · SHAPE AND STYLE · 1

# Motifs and phrases

A tune is built like a story. A tiny idea, the **motif**, grows into a **phrase**, a musical sentence; two phrases make a question and its answer. Spot the building blocks and a page of notes turns into a few ideas.

THE SECRET

**A motif is a word, a phrase a sentence: a question ends away from home, an answer comes home.**




*Words, sentences, paragraphs*

## A motif




Four notes, short-short-short-long: Beethoven builds the whole first movement of his Fifth Symphony from them. A motif is short (2 to 6 notes) and easy to recognise: its **rhythm** and its **shape** come back again and again.

## Phrases: question and answer




Ode to Joy: two 4-bar phrases. The first ends on D, away from home (a question); the second comes home to C (an answer).

THE RULE

**Most phrases are 4 bars long. A question phrase ends away from the key note; the answer comes home to it.**

PART VII · SHAPE AND STYLE · 1 · CONTINUED

EXAMPLE 1

### Question or answer?



1. **The key is C major.** What is the home note?
2. **The last note** of this phrase is…?
3. **Is it home?**

It ends on D, not C: a **question**. The answer phrase that follows ends on C.

EXAMPLE 2

### Find the motif



1. **Look at bar 1:** what shape and rhythm?
2. **Bars 2 and 3:** the same shape?
3. **Where** does each start?

Step, step, long: three notes. It comes **three times**, each a step higher.

GAME

### How many phrases?

| 1 | 2 | 3 |
|---|---|---|
| 8 bars | 12 bars | 16 bars |

Each phrase is 4 bars long. How many phrases in a tune of…

Answer: 1 two · 2 three · 3 four.

TRY IT · 10 SECONDS




**Sing a question, then an answer.**

Sing the question and stop on the D: it hangs in the air. Now sing the answer and land on C.

YOU KNOW THIS

### Beethoven, Symphony No. 5




"Da-da-da-**DUM**": the most famous motif ever written. Listen to the first minute and count how many times it comes back.

**Try it.** Tap the rhythm on the lid, then sing it a step lower.

TRAP

× Playing every note the same: each phrase has one high point to grow towards.

SEE ALSO

Slurs and phrases p. 80 · Cadences p. 139

PRACTISE IT

Online: Library › Phrases

PART VII · SHAPE AND STYLE · 2

# Repetition and sequence

Composers make one idea go a long way. They say it again, say it again higher or lower, let another hand copy it, or say something completely new.

**THE SECRET**

**Again, again higher, again in the other hand, or something new.**




*Four ways to use one idea*

| NAME | WHAT HAPPENS |
|---|---|
| **repetition** | the same notes again |
| **sequence** | the same shape, starting higher or lower |
| **imitation** | another hand or voice copies the idea |
| **contrast** | something new: a different shape or rhythm |



A rising sequence: C D E, D E F, E F G.

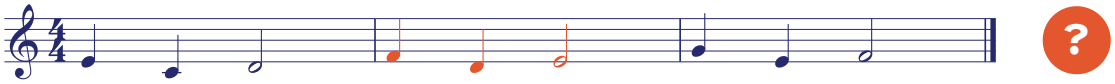


A falling sequence: each step one note lower.

**TWO-MINUTE DRILL** Take any three-note motif and play it as a sequence, starting on every white key from C up to the next C, then back down.

EXAMPLE 1

**Repetition or sequence?**



1. **Bar 1:** which notes?
2. **Bar 2:** the same notes, or the same shape on new notes?
3. **Bar 3?**

Same shape, a step higher each bar: a **sequence**.

PART VII · SHAPE AND STYLE · 2 · CONTINUED

EXAMPLE 2

**Which hand copies?**



1. **The right hand** starts with C D E F G E C.
2. **The left hand** waits a bar. Then?
3. **Same notes**, how many octaves lower?

The left hand **imitates** the right one bar later, two octaves down.

EXAMPLE 3

**Where is the contrast?**



1. **Bars 1 and 2:** same or different?
2. **Bar 3:** what changes, the notes or the rhythm?
3. **Bar 4?**

Bars 1–2 repeat; **bar 3** brings something new: long notes on G.

GAME

**Which way?**

1 same notes

2 one step up

3 left hand copies

4 new rhythm

Name each one.

Answer: 1 repetition · 2 sequence · 3 imitation · 4 contrast.

TRY IT · 10 SECONDS



**Make a sequence.**

Play C D E, then D E F, then E F G with fingers 1 2 3. Now go down: G F E, F E D, E D C.

YOU KNOW THIS

**Frère Jacques**



Every bar is said **twice**: repetition. Sung as a round, each voice enters two bars after the last: imitation.

**Try it.** Sing it as a round with a friend.

TRAP

× Calling any repeat a sequence: a sequence moves to new notes.

SEE ALSO
Motifs and phrases p. 148 · Texture p. 152

PRACTISE IT
Online: Library › Patterns

PART VII · SHAPE AND STYLE · 3

# Texture

Texture is how many lines sound at once, and how they fit together: one line alone, a tune with chords, or several tunes woven together like threads in cloth.

**THE SECRET**

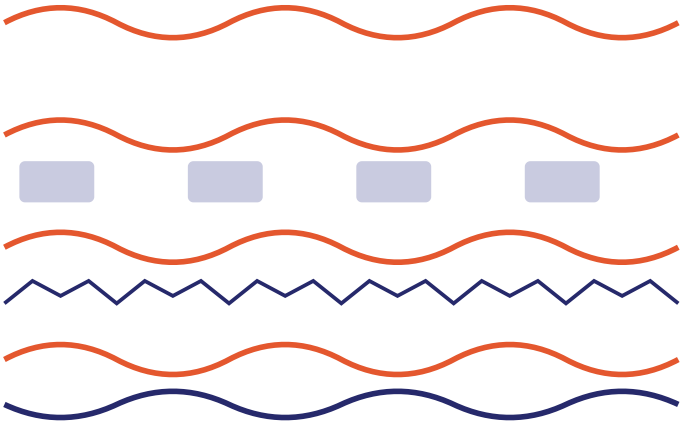
**Count the lines: one alone, a tune with chords, or tunes woven together.**

**one line**
monophony

**a tune with chords**
melody and accompaniment

**a tune over broken chords**
Alberti bass, arpeggios

**two tunes at once**
polyphony



*Thin or thick: count the threads*

| WORD | WHAT YOU HEAR |
|---|---|
| **monophonic** | one line alone, or in octaves (unison) |
| **homophonic** | a tune with chords underneath: melody and accompaniment |
| **polyphonic** (contrapuntal) | two or more tunes at once, each its own |
| **Alberti bass** | a broken chord rocking low–high–middle–high |
| **block chords** | all the chord notes struck together |



Melody and block chords.



Polyphony: two tunes, each with its own rhythm.

GAME

**One line or more?**

1 **a tune alone** 2 **a tune and chords** 3 **two tunes at once**

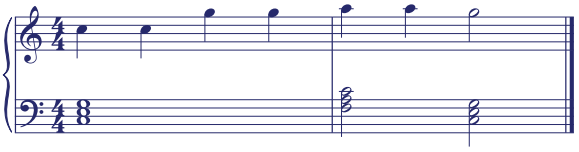
Name the texture.

Answer: 1 monophonic · 2 homophonic · 3 polyphonic.

PART VII · SHAPE AND STYLE · 3 · CONTINUED

EXAMPLE 1

### Name the texture



1. **The right hand:** a tune or chords?
2. **The left hand:** a tune or chords?
3. **So** which word?

A tune over chords: **homophonic**, melody and accompaniment.

EXAMPLE 2

### Which hand has the tune?



1. **The right hand** repeats two-note chords.
2. **The left hand** moves step by step.
3. **Which one** should sing out?

The **left hand** has the tune: play it louder, keep the right-hand chords soft.

YOU KNOW THIS

### Mozart, Sonata in C, K. 545



The right hand sings; the left hand rocks **C G E G**: an Alberti bass, the sound of the Classical style.

**Try it.** Play only the left hand, softly and evenly.

TRAP

- × Letting the accompaniment cover the tune: tune louder, chords softer.
- × Losing one of two tunes: practise each hand alone and sing it.

SEE ALSO
Chords under a melody p. 142 · Styles p. 159

PRACTISE IT
Online: Library › Texture

PART VII · SHAPE AND STYLE · 4

# Changing key

Music can travel to a new key and come home again: a **modulation**. The signpost is a new sharp, flat or natural that keeps coming back, and a cadence that lands in the new key.

THE SECRET

**A new sharp or flat that keeps coming back, then a cadence: you are in a new key.**

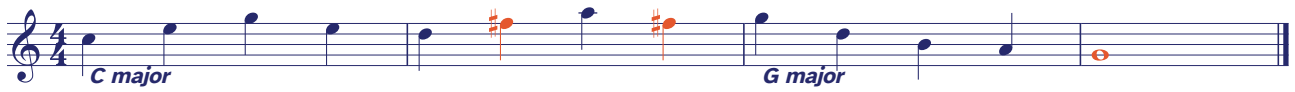



*A trip away, and home again*

## The nearest keys

A piece in C major usually visits the keys next door on the circle of fifths (p. 105): only one note changes.

| FROM C MAJOR TO | THE SIGNPOST | WHY IT IS CLOSE |
|---|---|---|
| **G major** | F♯ appears | the key a 5th up (one more sharp) |
| **F major** | B♭ appears | the key a 4th up (one more flat) |
| **A minor** | G♯ appears | the relative minor (same key signature) |




Bar 1 in C major; F♯ twice in bar 2, then the phrase lands on G: now G major.

EXAMPLE 1

**Where does the key change?**




1. **Find the accidental.**
2. **Which major key** has one flat, B♭?
3. **Where** does the phrase land?

B♭ in bar 2 and again in bar 3, landing on F: **F major**.

PART VII · SHAPE AND STYLE · 4 · CONTINUED

EXAMPLE 2

**Which nearby key?**

## In G major, a C♯ keeps appearing ?

1. **G major** has one sharp, F♯.
2. **C♯ is one more sharp.**
3. **Which key** has F♯ and C♯?

**D major**, the key a 5th up: one more sharp.

EXAMPLE 3

**A new key, or just passing?**

## One F♯ in a bar of C major, then F♮ everywhere after ?

1. **Does the F♯ come back?**
2. **Is there a cadence** in G?
3. **So**, a new key?

No: one passing F♯ is a decoration. A modulation **keeps** its new note and lands with a cadence.

GAME

**Where to next?**

1. C major + F♯
2. C major + B♭
3. G major + C♯
4. F major + E♭

Which nearby key has the music moved to?

Answer: 1 G major · 2 F major · 3 D major · 4 B♭ major.

TRY IT · 10 SECONDS




**Hear the pull.**

Play the four bars twice: once with F♮ in bar 2, once with F♯. With the F♯, the G at the end sounds like a new home.

THINK OF IT A modulation is a holiday: new scenery for a while, but the piece usually comes home at the end.

TRAP

- × Taking one passing accidental as a new key: it must keep coming back.
- × Missing the way home: most pieces end in the key they began in, so watch for the old note returning.

SEE ALSO

The circle of fifths p. 105 · Cadences p. 139

PRACTISE IT

Online: Library › Keys

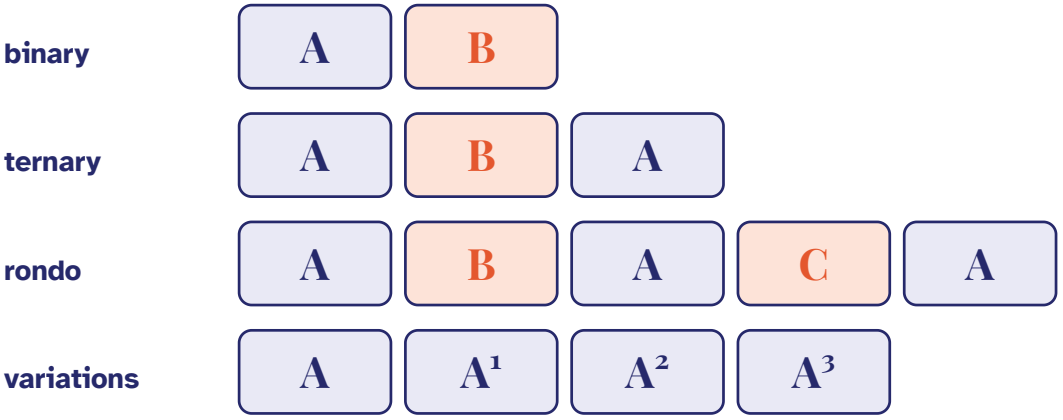
PART VII · SHAPE AND STYLE · 5

# Form

Form is the map of a whole piece: which sections come, in what order, and which come back. Letters name them: **A** for the first idea, **B** for the next new one, and so on.

THE SECRET

**Same music, same letter. New music, next letter.**




*The map of a piece, in letters*

| FORM | LETTERS | SHAPE | YOU KNOW IT FROM |
|---|---|---|---|
| **binary** | A B | two halves, each often repeated | Baroque dances: minuets, gigues |
| **ternary** | A B A | out, away, and back | many short Romantic pieces |
| **rondo** | A B A C A | A keeps coming back between new ideas | Beethoven, Für Elise |
| **theme and variations** | A $A^1$ $A^2$ $A^3$ | one tune, dressed differently each time | Mozart's variations on "Twinkle" |
| **strophic** | A A A | the same music for every verse | hymns, folk songs |
| **verse and chorus** | V C V C | the chorus words stay the same | pop songs |

THE RULE

**Same music, same letter. New music, the next letter. A little changed: add a small number ($A^1$).**

LISTEN FOR IT

**Petzold**
Minuet in G (Notebook for Anna Magdalena Bach; once thought to be Bach's)
binary: two halves, each repeated

**Beethoven**
Für Elise
rondo: A B A C A

**Mozart**
Twelve Variations on "Ah vous dirai-je, Maman"
theme and variations, on the tune of Twinkle

PART VII · SHAPE AND STYLE · 5 · CONTINUED

EXTRA · GOING FURTHER

### Sonata form

The big first movements of sonatas and symphonies: an **exposition** (two themes, the second in a new key), a **development** (the themes taken apart and moved through keys), and a **recapitulation** (both themes again, now at home).

EXAMPLE 1

**Which letter makes it ternary?**




1. **A B** alone: two sections.
2. **Ternary** goes out, away and...?
3. **Which letter** fills the box?

**A**. A B is binary; A B **A** is ternary.

EXAMPLE 2

**Which form?**




1. **Count the sections.**
2. **Which one keeps coming back?**
3. **What comes between?**

A returns between two new ideas: a **rondo**.

EXAMPLE 3

**Map Twinkle**




1. **Bars 1–4:** call them A.
2. **Bars 5–8:** new or the same?
3. **The last four bars** (not shown) repeat bars 1–4.

Bars 5–8 are new: B. Then A again: **A B A**, ternary.

TRY IT · 10 SECONDS



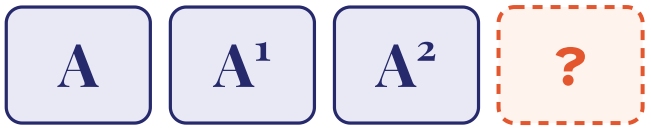

**Map a piece you play.**

Give every 4-bar phrase a letter. Same music, same letter. What form is it?

PART VII · SHAPE AND STYLE · 5 · CONTINUED

EXAMPLE 4

**What comes next?**




1. **A** is the theme.
2. **A¹ and A²**: the same tune, dressed differently.
3. **The next one** is called...?

**A³**: a third variation. Theme and variations keep one tune and change its clothes.

GAME

**Name the form**

| 1 | 2 | 3 | 4 |
|---|---|---|---|
| A B | A B A | A B A C A | A A¹ A² A³ |

Name each map.

Answer: 1 binary · 2 ternary · 3 rondo · 4 theme and variations.

HOW TO

**Learn a piece by its map**

1. **Letter the sections** in pencil.
2. **Learn A first**: it comes back, so it pays twice.
3. **Then the new sections**, and practise the joins between them.

YOU KNOW THIS

**Beethoven, Für Elise**




The famous opening tune is **A**. It is heard three times, with two new sections in between: a rondo.

**Try it.** Listen and raise your hand every time A returns.

THINK OF IT Form is the floor plan of a house: once you know the rooms, you never get lost in it.

TRAP

- × Giving every phrase a new letter: same music, same letter.
- × Counting a repeat as a new section: A played twice is still A.

SEE ALSO

Repeats and road signs p. 71 · Changing key p. 154

PRACTISE IT

Online: Library › Form

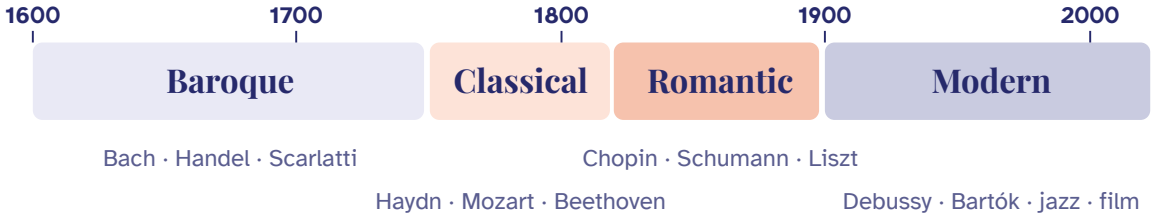
PART VII · SHAPE AND STYLE · 6

# Styles through time

Music changes with its time, like clothes and buildings. Four big periods cover most piano music. Each has a sound you can learn to recognise, and a way it likes to be played.

THE SECRET

**Listen for the texture, the ornaments and the pedal: they tell you the century.**




## *Four centuries, four sounds*

| PERIOD | LISTEN FOR |
|---|---|
| **Baroque** 1600–1750 | harpsichord and organ; two or more tunes woven together; many ornaments; loud or soft in blocks; a steady beat throughout |
| **Classical** 1750–1820 | the new piano; a clear tune with an Alberti bass; tidy 4-bar phrases; crescendos and contrasts |
| **Romantic** 1820–1900 | big feelings; rich chords and the pedal; rubato; the whole keyboard, from very soft to very loud |
| **Modern** 1900–today | new scales and harmonies, surprising rhythms; impressionism, jazz, minimalism, film music |

## Playing in style

| | PEDAL | TIME | TOUCH |
|---|---|---|---|
| **Baroque** | little or none | steady | clear, often detached |
| **Classical** | light | steady | neat, even, singing tune |
| **Romantic** | rich | rubato | deep, legato |
| **Modern** | as marked | as marked | whatever the music asks |

LISTEN FOR IT

**Notebook for Anna Magdalena Bach**
Minuet in G (Petzold)
two lines, a steady dance

**Mozart**
Sonata in C, K. 545
Alberti bass, clear phrases

**Chopin**
Nocturnes
a singing tune, rubato, pedal

PART VII · SHAPE AND STYLE · 6 · CONTINUED

EXAMPLE 1

**Which period?**

**A tune over an Alberti bass, tidy 4-bar phrases** ?

1. **Alberti bass:** which period did it belong to?
2. **Tidy phrases**, question and answer.
3. **So?**

**Classical**: think Mozart.

EXAMPLE 2

**Which period?**

**Two equal tunes, many trills, written for harpsichord** ?

1. **Two tunes woven together**: which texture?
2. **Harpsichord**, before the piano.
3. **So?**

**Baroque**: think Bach.

EXAMPLE 3

**Which period?**

**Rubato, rich pedalled chords, huge leaps across the keyboard** ?

1. **Rubato**: time stretched for feeling.
2. **Rich chords** held in the pedal.
3. **So?**

**Romantic**: think Chopin.

GAME

**Who belongs where?**

| 1 | 2 | 3 | 4 |
|---|---|---|---|
| Bach | Mozart | Chopin | Debussy |

Match each composer to a period.

Answer: 1 Baroque · 2 Classical · 3 Romantic · 4 Modern.

TRAP

- × Pedalling Bach like Chopin: Baroque music needs little or no pedal.
- × Romantic rubato in Mozart: keep Classical time steady.

SEE ALSO
Ornaments p. 88 · The pedals p. 85

PRACTISE IT
Online: Library › Styles

PART VII · SHAPE AND STYLE · TIPS

# When a piece goes nowhere

Every note can be right and the piece still wander. The fix is to see the shape: where the phrases go, what comes back, and where the high point is.

TIP

### What you notice, what to check

| WHAT YOU NOTICE | CHECK | TURN TO |
|---|---|---|
| Every bar sounds the same | **the phrases:** where does each one grow? | p. 148 |
| It feels like a list of notes | **the motif** and its sequences | p. 150 |
| The tune is lost | **the texture:** which line sings? | p. 152 |
| A passage suddenly feels strange | **a new key:** look for the new accidental | p. 154 |
| You lose your place | **the form:** letter the sections | p. 156 |
| It sounds out of style | **the period:** pedal, time and touch | p. 159 |

## Four ways to find the shape

1. **Pencil the phrases**
   Draw a curve over each phrase and mark its high point.

2. **Letter the sections**
   Write A, B, A in the margin. Practise each section on its own.

3. **Sing the tune**
   Sing the top line while you play the rest softly.

4. **Listen to a recording**
   Follow the score and hear the shape before you play it.

EXAMPLE

### Where is the high point?




1. **Sing it.**
2. **Which note** is highest?
3. **Grow to it**, then let the phrase fall.

The **As in bar 2**: grow to them, then fall home to C.

THINK OF IT A map does not make the journey, but it stops you getting lost.